

Who Shapes Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence?

Procedure 2022/0051(COD) – 1,455 amendments, 734 disclosed lobbying meetings, 516 organisations, 15 MEPs

The lobbying landscape

The Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (CSDDD) attracted one of the more intensely contested lobbying environments in this legislative cycle. Across 734 disclosed meetings – 128 with Commission officials, the remainder with European Parliament contacts – 516 distinct organisations engaged on the file. Of the 128 Commission meetings with recorded notes, 79 contained substantive position data.

Among the top 30 most active organisations, civil society and non-commercial actors account for a substantial share of meeting activity. The European Coalition for Corporate Justice leads all organisations with 32 meetings, followed by Global Witness and the European Trade Union Confederation (14 meetings each), Anti-Slavery International, Frank Bold Society, and ClientEarth (11 each), and Clean Clothes Campaign, Friends of the Earth Europe, and Human Rights Watch (10 each). The most active commercial and employer-side actors include the Bundesverband der Deutschen Industrie (13 meetings), the Responsible Business Alliance (10), and VNO-NCW (9). The top organisations lobbied primarily on climate transition plans, stakeholder engagement requirements, and civil liability – the three provisions that function as the directive’s core enforcement architecture.

Commission-level meeting activity was concentrated on company scope thresholds (11 meetings), climate transition plans (10), and third-country company coverage (6). The dominant positions from commercial actors centred on CSDDD simplification under the Omnibus package, with most explicitly seeking to narrow scope thresholds, reduce value-chain depth requirements, or limit civil liability exposure.

The key statistical finding

A Fisher’s exact test on the relationship between Lobby Exposure Index (LEI) group and thematic overlap group across all 15 MEPs in this sample produced a p-value of 0.007. This is a statistically significant association (n=15): MEPs classified in the higher-exposure group all show thematic overlap between their amendment activity and their lobbying contact themes, while no MEP in the lower-exposure group shows such overlap (contingency: 5 high-LEI/high-overlap, 2 high-LEI/low-overlap, 0 low-LEI/high-overlap, 8 low-LEI/low-overlap). The result is consistent with a pattern in which MEPs who meet more lobbyists on a given file tend to amend more broadly across the themes those lobbyists raise, though the small sample size limits the generalisability of this finding. The two Pearson correlation tests – LEI against total amendments and Amendment-Lobby Alignment Score (ALAS) against amendments on commercial themes – did not reach statistical significance (p=0.45 and p=0.75 respectively), indicating no linear relationship between raw exposure and amendment volume.

Directional alignment

Directional alignment data – comparing whether individual amendments move toward or away from disclosed lobby positions on matched themes – was computable for five MEPs with overlapping amendment and meeting activity.

Axel Voss (EPP, Shadow) has the highest alignment fraction among MEPs with evaluable data: 37 of 65 amendment-position pairs move in the same direction as the lobby positions, with 18 moving away and 10 neutral, giving a fraction of 0.57. Notably, the majority of his “toward” score derives from stakeholder engagement requirements (21 of 25 pairs scored toward), where his amendments reinforce protections advocated by civil society organisations such as Anti-Slavery International – not the German industry groups that dominate his meeting log. Heidi Hautala (Greens/EFA, Shadow) shows 27 of 50 pairs moving toward lobby positions (fraction 0.54), concentrated in stakeholder engagement requirements where her amendments align closely with the civil society coalition’s positions. Tiemo Wölken (S&D, Opinion Rapporteur) has 7 of 15 pairs toward (fraction 0.47).

Lara Wolters (S&D, Rapporteur) – the lead rapporteur with the highest number of disclosed meetings at 153 – presents a different pattern: 28 pairs move toward lobby positions while 32 move away, for a fraction of 0.37. Amendments move against lobby positions more often than toward them, driven largely by her company scope threshold amendments, which expand CSDDD coverage in a direction opposed by multiple commercial organisations she met. René Repasi (S&D, Opinion Rapporteur) shows 9 of 25 pairs toward and 8 away (fraction 0.36), with mixed directionality across climate transition plans and value chain depth.

Theme-level observations

Value chain depth generated the highest amendment activity of any theme by a substantial margin (365 amendments), and attracted moderate lobbying exposure (7 meetings, 11 active organisations). Civil liability generated 140 amendments on only 3 disclosed meetings, suggesting that despite being a principal fault line in Commission consultations – where organisations ranging from Baker Hughes to CEFIC explicitly targeted Article 22 – formal EP contacts on this theme were limited. This gap could reflect informal channels not captured in disclosed data, or a strategic choice by industry to concentrate civil liability lobbying at Commission level during the Omnibus revision rather than in EP committee.

The most striking divergence between amendment and lobbying activity appears in two themes. Enforcement and supervisory authority generated 166 amendments – the third highest count – but only 1 disclosed meeting with a single organisation (Samsung Electronics Europe). Human rights standards referenced attracted 108 amendments and zero disclosed lobbying meetings. Environmental harm definition similarly produced 48 amendments with no meeting activity on record. These themes appear to be driven primarily by rapporteur and shadow rapporteur positions rather than by externally disclosed contact, though the absence of meeting records does not establish an absence of external input.

Climate transition plans, by contrast, attracted the second-highest lobbying meeting count (10 meetings, 16 active organisations) but generated only 60 amendments – relatively modest given the volume of disclosed engagement.

Limitations

This analysis is based exclusively on meetings disclosed in the EU Transparency Register and publicly available amendment documents; informal contacts, phone calls, written correspondence, and meetings not entered into the register are unobservable and may be material. Temporal ordering has not been verified – some lobbying meetings may postdate the amendments they are compared against, meaning the directional alignment calculations cannot establish a sequence of contact preceding amendment.

This briefing was produced by an automated analysis pipeline combining EU Transparency Register data, EP amendment texts, and AI-assisted position extraction. All statistical claims are directly derived from the underlying data; interpretations are qualified accordingly.